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## **Alexander and the Almohads: telling the stories of antiquity before and after Las Navas**

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In this essay, I examine the extent to which the narration of versions of the life of Alexander the Great were responsive to the battle at Las Navas de Tolosa, and the ways in which subsequent generations of writers used those romances to explore the battle and its consequences. With particular reference to two codices, containing strikingly similar collections of texts relating both to the life of Alexander the Great and to the rise of the Almohad Empire, I describe the persistence of Alexander romances in the construction of memory and note the similar ways in which later Jewish and Christian historians used them to reflect upon the battle at Las Navas de Tolosa and its religious and political underpinnings.

**Keywords:** Alexander the Great; Libro de Alexandre; Almohads; Moses Maimonides; Mark of Toledo; Las Navas de Tolosa

It is a truism learned early in a scholarly career that the life of Alexander the Great tells its reader far more about the author than about the subject; the Macedonian conqueror-king lived such a spectacular and diverse experience that, in his literary and historiographic afterlife, he could become all things to all people. We hear echoes, for instance, of Johann Gustav Droysen's nineteenth-century advocacy for German unification under Prussian rule in his coining of the term "*Hellenizing*" to describe Alexander's cultural influence over vast swaths of Asia. Parallels abound in the writing of the historians, travelers, and bureaucrats of Victorian England who cast Alexander as the consummate colonial administrator. More recently, Rory Stewart, denizen of the recent Western military efforts in Iraq and Afghanistan – frequently characterized by their dramatic lack of knowledge of the local cultures – has observed: "The more we produce about Alexander the less we seem to understand him;"<sup>1</sup> a statesman working in a world of unknowns thereby emphasizes the elements of the unknowable about Alexander's life. I would like to present here the case of two manuscript codices that form part of this millennia-long trend that inextricably connects literary and imaginative explanations of antiquity to a contemporaneous political scene. Each of them ties the life of Alexander the Great – through their textual content and idiosyncratic compilation – first with the oeuvre of a translator living and working in Castile during the first decade and a half of the thirteenth century, and second with the theological works of Almohadizing religious-philosophical writers who either established the tenets of Almohad doctrine or incorporated it into later textual contexts. The manuscripts themselves were created long after the battle at Las Navas de Tolosa, but their parallel combinations of text make them a powerful and evocative memorial to that battle, its causes, and its

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<sup>1</sup>Stewart, "Great Expectations."

consequences. They challenge modern readers to understand the value of Alexander for the communities that struggled with the immediate and long-term fallout of that battle.

The best-known example of Alexander literature composed in the temporal and geographic environs of Las Navas de Tolosa is the anonymous Ibero-Romance work of *mester de clerecía* known as the *Libro de Alexandre*. Although the exact year of its composition remains a question, the vast majority of scholarship places it within less than a decade of the battle; and just as it has been considered to be responsive to other contemporaneous events – the Fourth Lateran Council of 1215, for example<sup>2</sup> – it must also be considered responsive to the broad circumstances that shaped events at Las Navas (if not to the battle itself). The composition of this text so close in time and space to the waging of war, in combination with unique characteristics that the text attributes to the figure of Alexander, which will be delineated below, makes this Alexander romance, and its sources and component parts, inextricably linked to the historical moment of 1212. In the central Iberian Peninsula – we do not know the site of the *Libro de Alexandre*'s composition any more certainly than we know its date – the figure of Alexander the Great becomes connected with the ongoing struggle between Almohad and Castilian forces.

In her 1999 monograph on the composition of the *Libro de Alexandre*, Amaia Arizaleta argued that the speeches that the Castilian Alexander makes when he musters his troops cast him clearly as a monarch who would be recognizable to the Castilian-led forces at Las Navas and as a figure whom they themselves would have deemed worthy of their admiration;<sup>3</sup> Julian Weiss goes as far as to describe this vision of Alexander as that of a “monarch of the Reconquest.”<sup>4</sup> I would prefer to separate out the idea of a recognizable monarch from that of a prince of the Reconquest: a term too general and too fraught to be productive to apply to battles in which religiously mixed armies pursued a wide variety of imperial, expansionist, and economic goals. Yet regardless of how one elects to view the nature of the ideology driving the events of 1212, the protagonist of the *Libro de Alexandre* and the other local Alexanders – including those appearing in the other Alexander romances written in Latin, Hebrew, and Arabic that were either circulating in or even native to the Iberian Peninsula – would certainly have represented a recognizable model: the genre and the literary figure had the capacity to be highly responsive to contemporary concerns.

The *Libro de Alexandre* is a text composed both of component parts and of original material, deftly combined and edited by the work's anonymous poet. The major sources of the borrowed material are the Latin epics *Alexandreis* and *Historia Proeliis* and the French *Roman d'Alexandre*. The *Historia Proeliis* is of particular interest in the context of cross-cultural readings of Alexander's life because, as the surviving Latin translation of the most important Greek retelling of Alexander's biography, it enjoyed the widest dissemination and was the basis of the greatest number of translations into other classical languages and into vernacular tongues; the majority of medieval readers familiar with the life of Alexander would have been familiar with variations upon this version. Versions of the *Historia Proeliis* form the backbone of both texts under present discussion, Mazarine MS 780 and Beinecke Additional Hebrew MS Suppl. 103<sup>5</sup>; each has a version of the *Historia* bound with statements of Almohad and Almohadizing doctrine. The Mazarine codex, copied and compiled in 1400, likely in England, contains both the *Historia Proeliis* and several Arabic texts translated in the early thirteenth century into Latin by Mark of Toledo, at the behest of

<sup>2</sup>Franchini, “El IV Concilio de Letrán,” 31–74; Arizaleta, *La Translation d'Alexandre*, 258.

<sup>3</sup>Arizaleta, *La Translation d'Alexandre*, 258.

<sup>4</sup>Weiss, *The “Mester de Clerecía,”* 123.

<sup>5</sup>*Important Hebrew Manuscripts and Printed Books*. In scholarship published before 2003, and in the catalogue of the Institute of Microfilmed Hebrew Manuscripts, Jerusalem, this manuscript is referred to by its previous institutional classmark, Jews' College London MS 145.

the archbishop of that city, Rodrigo Jiménez de Rada. These Arabic texts included the Almohad *aqidah*, or credo, sometimes attributed to the founder of the movement, Ibn Tūmart; other short statements of doctrine by Ibn Tūmart; and one of seven surviving copies of Mark's Latin translation of the *Qur'ān*. The Beinecke codex, copied in an Italian hand in 1520 from an earlier Vorlage, comprises a single manuscript text, the Hebrew translation of a now-lost Arabic version of the *Historia Proeliis*,<sup>6</sup> followed by a colophon which falsely attributes the Hebrew translation to Samuel ibn Tibbon, scion of a famed family of translators and best known as the authorized Hebrew translator of Moses Maimonides's *The Guide of the Perplexed*. The colophon of the Beinecke codex goes on to become a referendum on how best to translate the Arabic-language theological and philosophical texts of Maimonides, a thinker described by Sarah Stroumsa and other modern scholars as Almohadizing in his modes and methods of reasoning, making decisions and rendering opinions on a wide variety of matters. In a recent monograph, Stroumsa points out that although Maimonides was far too influenced by Mu'tazilism to be a true Almohad thinker, his worldview was "permeated" by theirs,<sup>7</sup> particularly in his manner of applying various principles of *uṣūl al-fiqh* (Islamic jurisprudence) to Jewish legal-religious decisions.<sup>8</sup> It should also be noted that both Samuel and Mark were working in Toledo around 1208 – Mark on his Latin translation of the *Qur'ān* and Samuel on the Hebrew translation of Aristotle's *Meteorologies* – placing them at the intellectual and power center of the political entity that would successfully challenge the Almohads in battle in 1212.<sup>9</sup> Each of these two codices, then, literally binds a comment upon an Almohad or Almohadist line of thought with the work (or at least *purported* work) of a Toledo-based, early thirteenth-century translator and a life of Alexander the Great, memorializing the Las Navas years as ones in which a strong king finds his fate metaphorically bound to that of a theologically radical group of Berber Muslims. The two volumes become an argument-by-codicology for a vision of the early thirteenth century that aligns the rise and fall of the Almohads with Iberian literary tastes. Both codices represent historical memories of the period: later reckonings of the early thirteenth century that portray the period in remarkably similar ways, despite their contrasting origins.

In his essay in this present volume, Thomas Burman describes the surprising lack of impact that the text of Mark's *Liber Alchorani* had in the Iberian Peninsula, and in effect, this manuscript offers a similar conclusion: while it may have neither circulated among the readers closest to its creation nor influenced their view of Arabo-Islamic culture, its existence, or the ignorance of it was critical in the contemporaneous and historical construction of the period of time, its political and military events, and its literature by intellectual forces outside of Iberia and after the early decades of the thirteenth century. The same is true with respect to the Beinecke codex. In both of these cases, later transmitters of knowledge understood Almohad and Almohadizing doctrine to be concomitant to the *Historia Proeliis*. This situation presents a variety of questions: why, by later years, was this the sensible way for both Jewish and Christian authors and redactors to remember the events of Las Navas and at least some of the ideologies that drove them? Are these codices useful historical documents in and of themselves? That is, is there anything to be

<sup>6</sup>For more information on both the stemma and provenance of this text, consult Wout van Bekkum's introduction to his edition of the manuscript (*A Hebrew Alexander Romance*).

<sup>7</sup>Stroumsa, *Maimonides in His World*, 53.

<sup>8</sup>Stroumsa, *Maimonides in His World*, 61–79. It is also worth observing that the notion of looking at prominent leaders of non-Almohad, non-Muslim communities as acting in an Almohad or Almohadizing fashion has gained traction in recent years. See, for example, Fierro, "Alfonso X the Wise," 175–98.

<sup>9</sup>Ibn Tibbon, *Otot ha-Shamayim*; Burman, "The Qur'ān Translations of Mark of Toledo and Flavius Mithradates."

learned about the first two decades of the thirteenth century? And what significance does Alexander hold for this particular set of circumstances?

The later implications of this question, those that get at the heart of the creation of these strikingly parallel manuscripts, are the subject of some of my current work in progress. For now, I should like to take as given that we can use these two codices and the fact of their binding as historical documents that “write,” by their very existences, a narrative chronicling the years running up to and following the battle at Las Navas de Tolosa. In other words, when we consider these texts for what they are on the surface – books that privilege and tie together Alexander and the Almohads – these two manuscripts become wordless historical studies of the early thirteenth century. And as such, any consideration of the proximate context of these two manuscripts invites readers to consider what they can tell us about Las Navas. The argument that the simple existence of these codices makes is that the fate of the Castilian king and his forces, whether narrated in Latin, Hebrew, Arabic or an inchoate Ibero-Romance, was bound closely in with that of the Almohads and of those who would adopt their religious and philosophical modes of thinking. Alexander’s moment in Iberia was the end of the first decade and the beginning of the second of the thirteenth century, when his literary biography was translated into Hebrew by someone who would have had us believe him to be a famed translator of an Almohadizing Jewish philosopher, adapted into Castilian by someone who might have had us believe that he was the poet Gonzalo de Berceo, and transmitted in Latin alongside the work of a Crusade bishop’s favored intellectual. That moment coincided with some of the most significant developments in the Almohad presence north of Gibraltar. The latter-day makers of these books offer a lyrical, elegant way of remembering 1212 in all its complexities.

Both the lection and dissemination of stories about the life of Alexander the Great in what we might call, broadly, the Las Navas years reflect the leadership values and the intellectual and religious trends that were current at their moment. A later and even more refined pen would ultimately write of a not-altogether-different kind of battle – the 1415 battle at Agincourt – that would also be memorialized in early modern literature: “Fathers that, like so many Alexanders,/ Have in these parts from morn till even fought/ and sheathed their swords for lack of argument.”<sup>10</sup> When the Crusaders at Las Navas finally sheathed their swords, the intellectual and textual world that they found as their spoils was nothing less than all Alexander and argument. The Alexander romances connected with the Almohadized and Almohadizing Jews and Christians of the Iberian Peninsula in the early thirteenth century reveal much more of their own lives than that of the subject himself. In this respect, the battle at Las Navas and the year 1212 are not a turning point signaling an ideological sea-change; rather, they – and the Alexandrine response to them – are a marker of literary affinities, continuity of purpose, and a pervasive, persistent, and diachronic intertextuality.

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<sup>10</sup>Shakespeare, *Henry V*, 3.1.19–21.

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